MILO

Installation Guide

Get the project from GitHub, open it in Visual Studio Code, and run the learning app on Windows.

GitHub repository	App stack
https://github.com/hamsineeganesh/milo-learning-app.git	React + Vite frontend Express + Gemini backend

1. Get the project from GitHub

Recommended: clone it in VS Code

1. Open Visual Studio Code.

2. Press **Ctrl + Shift + P** to open the Command Palette.

3. Type **Git: Clone** and select it.

4. Paste the repository address below, then press Enter:

```
https://github.com/hamsineeganesh/milo-learning-app.git
```

5. Choose a folder on your computer where you want to keep the project.

6. When VS Code asks whether to open the repository, choose **Open**.

Alternative: download a ZIP

On GitHub, click the green **Code** button, choose **Download ZIP**, extract the ZIP, then in VS Code select **File > Open Folder** and choose the extracted **milo-learning-app** folder.

For future GitHub updates, cloning is more convenient than downloading a new ZIP each time.

2. Check that the correct folder is open

In VS Code, the Explorer should show the project folders, including **src**, **public**, and **server**. Open **Terminal > New Terminal**. The prompt should end in the project folder name (for example, **milo-learning-app>**), not **server>**.

Install and configure

3. Install the project packages

In the first VS Code terminal, confirm it is at the repository root (the folder containing the main package.json), then run:

```
npm.cmd install
```

The .cmd form works in PowerShell when Windows blocks the npm.ps1 script.

4. Add your Gemini key privately

The Parent Guide needs the backend API key. Create a file named **.env** inside the **server** folder. In VS Code Explorer, right-click **server** > **New File** > type **.env**.

```
GEMINI_API_KEY=your_Gemini_API_key_here
GEMINI_MODEL=gemini-3.8-flash
```

Keep the key private

Replace the example value with your own key. Do not put the key in React code, screenshots, or GitHub. The repository ignores .env files; do not force-add them. If a real key is ever uploaded, revoke it and create a new one.

5. Start the backend server

In the first terminal, run these commands. If it is already at the project root:

```
cd server
npm.cmd install
node .\index.js
```

Keep this terminal open. A successful start prints a message that Milo AI Server is running at http://localhost:5000.

If you see a missing API key message, confirm that **server/.env** exists, the key line is spelled exactly as shown, and then restart the backend.

Run MILO

6. Start the Vite website

Open a second VS Code terminal. Make sure the prompt is at the project root, not inside the server folder. If it ends in server>, enter cd .. first. Then run:

```
npm.cmd run dev
```

Vite prints a local address, usually http://localhost:5173/. If that port is busy, Vite may choose 5174 or another port. Open the exact address printed in the terminal.

Keep both terminals open while using the site:

Terminal 1	Terminal 2
Backend node .\index.js localhost:5000	Frontend npm.cmd run dev Vite address shown in terminal

7. Open and check the app

1. Open the Vite local address in a browser.

2. You should see the MILO homepage with Child and Caregiver choices.

3. Open Caregiver and try Ask MILO. Gemini replies need the backend running and the private API key configured.

4. If an AI request fails, check the backend terminal for its error and use the app's Try again button. A temporary Gemini busy response may clear after a short wait.

Common fixes

PowerShell says scripts are disabled	Use npm.cmd instead of npm for install and dev commands.
Browser says Cannot GET /	Open the Vite address from Terminal 2, not the backend address on port 5000.
Vite says an import or CSS file is missing	Check that the named file exists in src and that its spelling and capitalization match the import.
Port 5173 is already in use	Use the alternate Vite address printed in Terminal 2.
Need later GitHub updates	Save or commit your own edits first, then from the project root run git pull origin main.

GitHub stores the code and assets, not your local .env key. Keep your key on your computer and out of commits.